James Okun

Contact Information

Email: jokun@mit.edu

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), Cambridge, MA, United States

PhD in Economics, 2022—present

Brown University, Providence, RI, United States

Bachelor of Science with Honors in Applied Mathematics-Economics, 2020

Bachelor of Arts in Computer Science, 2020

Magna Cum Laude

Professional Experience

Predoctoral Research Assistant for Professor Amy Finkelstein 2020-2022

Teaching

A Crash Course in Basics of Programming, Replication, and Numerical Methods (MIT) 2025-2026
Instructor

Mathematical Econometrics (Brown) 2020
Teaching Assistant

Real Analysis (Brown) 2019-2020
Teaching Assistant

Deep Learning (Brown) 2019
Teaching Assistant

Multivariable Calculus (Brown) 2018
Teaching Assistant

Working Papers

"Public Procurement and Private Product Distribution: Evidence from WIC and the Infant Formula Market"
with Yuci Zhou, 2026

"Selective Admissions in Nursing Homes: Evidence from a Randomized Audit Study"
with Liran Einav, Amy Finkelstein, Jesse Gubb, and Neale Mahoney, 2026

"Racial Differences in Nursing Home Value Added"
with Liran Einav, Amy Finkelstein, and Neale Mahoney, 2026, *Revise and Resubmit, Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics*

Publications

"Pandemic Schooling Mode and Student Test Scores: Evidence from US School Districts"
with Rebecca Jack, Clare Halloran, and Emily Oster, *American Economic Review: Insights,* 2023

Honors and Awards

Alfred P. Sloan Foundation and Coefficient Giving Grant G-2026-79701	2026
J-PAL Health Care Delivery Initiative Grant	2026
Jerry A. Hausman Graduate Dissertation Fellowship · *MIT Economics Department*	2025-2027
Fiscal and Economic Effects of Innovation and Productivity Policies Fellowship · *NBER*	2025-2026
Supported by the Alfred P. Sloan Foundation grant G-2024-22690	
Aging and Health Graduate Fellowship · *NBER*	2024-2025
Supported by the National Institute on Aging grant T32-AG000186	
MIT Graduate Fellowship · *MIT*	2022-2024
Outstanding Thesis Award in Economics · *Brown University Economics Department*	2020
Pathfinder Scholarship in Mathematics · *Pathfinders*	2016

Professional Activities

Conference Presentations and Discussions

ASSA	2024

Service

Organizer, MIT Industrial Organization Tea/Lunch	2024-2026
President, MIT Graduate Economics Association	2024-2025
Treasurer, MIT Graduate Economics Association	2023-2024

Refereeing

Journal of Political Economy, American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization